Intergenerational Mobility in the Value of a Job*

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October 16, 2026

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Abstract

Intergenerational mobility is usually measured in income, yet workers value job amenities as well as pay. We measure intergenerational mobility in the value of a job, which reflects both amenities and pay. Using a revealed preference approach, we infer the value of each job from voluntary moves between jobs. We embed this approach in a job ladder model in which workers differ in preferences and job opportunities. Weekly benefit records let us distinguish quits, which reveal preferences, from layoffs, which do not. In Danish administrative data on parents and their children, we document that there is 37% less intergenerational persistence in job value than in earnings: the rank-rank slope is 0.11 in job value and 0.18 in earnings. A key reason behind this gap is that the children of high-earning parents tend to hold jobs that pay more but have worse amenities. Evidence from surveys suggests that these jobs are more demanding: they involve greater competition, longer hours, and greater time pressure.

Keywords: Intergenerational mobility, revealed preference, amenities
JEL Codes: J62, J32, J30

*We are grateful to Peter Arcidiacono, Rafael Dix-Carneiro, Michael Dinerstein, Gregor Jarosch, and Laura Pilossoph for patient advising and support. For helpful comments and suggestions, we thank Naoki Aizawa, Titan Alon, Jason Baron, Patrick Bayer, Flavio Cunha, Juanna Joensen, Matthias Kehrig, Andrea Lanteri, Felipe Lobel, Marjorie McElroy, Nirav Mehta, Chris Moser, Lukas Nord, Ryungha Oh, Michael Pollmann, Xincheng Qiu, and Isaac Sorkin, as well as seminar and conference participants at Atlanta Fed, Copenhagen Business School, Duke, VIVE, World Bank, and the Search and Matching Network (SaM) meeting in Amsterdam. This paper supersedes an earlier working paper circulated under the title "Intergenerational Mobility in Welfare: Wages and Amenities." All remaining errors are our own.

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